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CARRY THE CONTEXT

Shared work, separate voices: what AI should hold between us, and what it must never hold for us.

For most of my life the problem with work hasn't been effort. It has been the space between people. The handoff. The note that didn't make it to the next shift, the decision nobody wrote down, the file that lived in one person's head. I think the most useful thing artificial intelligence can do for schools and companies is to carry that space for us, so each of us is freer to bring our own judgment to it. Working together does not require thinking alike.

This paper makes that case, and it makes the case against getting it wrong. I run my own firm on these tools every day, including Anthropic's Claude and Cowork. In October 2026 Anthropic filed to go public, and a lot of the conversation will be about money. I want to have a different conversation: about what kind of work these tools make possible, what has to stay human, and how to tell the difference.

1. THE LIBRARY AND THE SCATTER

In 1994, about three percent of the classrooms in American public schools had the internet. By 2003 it was ninety-three percent. In less than a decade the library moved into every room. Students who once waited for a book to come back could read the world from a desk. That was a gift, and it still is.

Then the library moved into our pockets. The phone, the feed, the app for every task. We gained reach and lost the room. Today a single project at a small company can live across email, three chat threads, a shared drive, a calendar, a text message and someone's memory. A teacher's week is spread across a learning platform, a grade book, a parent app and a stack of sticky notes. Nothing is missing, exactly. It is just scattered.

The internet connected us to information. What it never did well was connect us on the work itself: one place where the people doing a job together can see what has happened, what was decided, and what comes next.

2. THE SEAM

I spent more than a decade in restaurants, in New York and San Francisco and elsewhere, in nearly every role a restaurant has: valet, busboy, dishwasher, server, bartender, manager. The lesson I took from all of it is that the meal is won or lost in the handoff. The table tells the server about the allergy. The server tells the line. The line tells the expo. If one of those three conversations drops a word, the kitchen can do everything else perfectly and still put someone in the hospital.

Every organization I have worked in since, from a law practice to an affordable-housing nonprofit, has the same seams. A nurse at shift change. A teacher handing the afternoon to an aide. A project manager passing a job site to the next crew. An attorney going on vacation in the middle of a closing. The work itself usually goes fine. The work between the work is where things fall through.

THE SEAM MATTERS MORE THAN THE ROOM.

We have spent decades making each room more efficient. We have spent far less making the seams hold.

3. WHAT A SHARED WORKSPACE ACTUALLY HOLDS

The new generation of AI work tools is different from a chatbot in one important way. A chatbot answers a question and forgets it. A shared workspace keeps the project: the files, the instructions, the decisions, the open questions, the scheduled follow-ups, and the connections to the other systems a team already uses. Claude and Cowork work this way. So, increasingly, do tools from other companies. Some large organizations are already moving: in April 2026 Freshfields, one of the world's largest law firms, gave 5,700 people across 33 offices access to Claude. Whether that becomes one table or 5,700 separate rooms is a design choice, not a given.

Used well, that kind of workspace can do something simple and powerful. It can tell the next person where things stand. It can turn a pile of notes into a handoff someone can read in two minutes. It can notice that four teachers scheduled four major projects for the same Friday. It can remind a team about the promise they made to a client three weeks ago. None of that requires the tool to decide anything. It requires the tool to remember, and to make what it remembers visible to the people who need it.

That is the whole idea in one line, and it is the line I keep coming back to:

THE SYSTEM SHOULD CARRY THE CONTEXT. PEOPLE SHOULD CARRY THE THINKING.

4. FIFTY PLACES IT HELPS

It is easy to talk about this in the abstract, so here is what it looks like on the ground. Each of these is a place where a shared workspace could carry the handoff, and each names what stays human. None of them is a claim that a given product does all of this today; they are the kind of workflow a permission-controlled shared workspace can support.

In a kindergarten, the teacher and the aide share the day's plan and the afternoon handoff. Human: how each child is supported. **In middle school,** shared assignment calendars flag four big projects due the same Friday. Human: what to assign and when. **In high school,** lab groups keep procedures and results across sessions. Human: the experiment and the conclusion. **In an art class,** a critique log follows each student's piece through its drafts. Human: the brush, the eye, the critique. **In the school orchestra,** parts and rehearsal notes stay current for every section. Human: the music.

In college, a research team sees who contributed what and what is still unresolved. Human: the question and the argument. **On a thesis committee,** three advisers' feedback lives in one place instead of three inboxes. Human: the scholarship. **In law school,** a moot-court team indexes its authorities and its open questions. Human: the reasoning and the advocacy. **In medical school and residency,** sign-out notes stop getting lost at three in the morning. Human: the patient at the bedside. **In an MBA program,** a team's conflicting assumptions surface before the presentation. Human: the strategy.

In a neighborhood restaurant, inventory, reservations and the broken walk-in reach the next shift, and the allergy travels from the table to the line. Human: hospitality and the care in the plate. **In a hospital,** discharge steps that would have stalled get flagged. Human: clinical judgment and the conversation with the patient. **On a construction site,** superseded drawings get caught before anyone builds from them. Human: workmanship and safety. **On a Wall Street desk,** research, trading and risk start the morning from one briefing. Human: the analysis and the trade.

In a small law firm, matters, deadlines and intake checklists are visible to everyone who needs them. Human: the advice and the client relationship. **In estate planning,** the client, the lawyer, the accountant and the financial adviser see the same plan. Human: the family's wishes. **In an affordable-housing deal,** the developer, lender, city and partners track one checklist. Human: the community it serves. **In a family business,** the founder's know-how is written down before it walks out the door. Human: the trust between generations. **In city government,** duplicate resident requests are grouped and stalled permits flagged. Human: public priorities and accountability.

The appendix carries the full list. The pattern holds across all of them: the tool holds the thread; the person holds the judgment.

5. WHAT MUST STAY HUMAN

There is a line between help that lets you sing and help that sings for you, and every one of these settings sits on it. Digital recording made it possible for almost anyone to record an album, and that was a good thing. Then the tools learned to tune the voice, and then to produce one. The question is not whether the technology is old or new. It is whether it is still your song.

In school this line is sharpest. The internet made research faster, but you still wrote the paper. Now the machine can write the paper. I am not cheering that. A paper you didn't write didn't teach you anything. Professors who are bringing back handwritten blue-book exams understand this. One of them, who keeps AI out of her course, put it simply: "I see writing as thinking." She is right. A student still has to read, write, paint, pick up a guitar and find a song. Nothing should find the words for them.

At work the line is about judgment and accountability. A tool can prepare the conflict check, but a lawyer decides whether there is a conflict. A tool can assemble the risk report, but a person decides what risk to take. A tool can draft the letter to the family, but someone who knows the family signs it. In my own practice the rule is short: the machine carries the parts; the human holds the whole.

6. THE COURTYARD

The strongest objection to everything above is that it will make us all the same. "AI puts everyone on the same page" sounds efficient. It can also sound like a march.

There is a scene in *Dead Poets Society* that every teacher remembers. Mr. Keating takes three boys into the courtyard and asks them to walk. They start out each in his own way. Within a few steps they have fallen into the same stride, and the rest of the class is clapping in time. Nobody told them to. Keating's point is how quietly and quickly the pull to conform works. One boy chooses not to walk at all, and Keating lets him.

That scene should be on the wall of every team adopting these tools. A shared workspace that produces one summary, one recommendation and one way of seeing the problem can flatten a group without anyone noticing. Everyone appears in step. Fewer people are actually thinking.

But there is an important distinction here. Not all sameness is conformity. A hospital needs one handoff checklist. A construction crew needs one current set of drawings. A court needs one set of procedural rules. That is procedure, and procedure is what lets different people work together safely. Conformity is something else: one way of thinking, one opinion, one voice. The goal is a shared foundation, not a shared script.

WORKING FROM THE SAME MAP. WALKING OUR OWN PATH.

7. THE CAVE

The same film has a second scene that matters as much. The boys revive Keating's old club, the Dead Poets Society, in a cave outside the school. They don't start by reading their own poems. They read the poets they love, out loud, to each other: Thoreau, Tennyson, others. Only later, haltingly, do they start reading their own.

That is how people actually learn: from the voices around them first, and then in their own. A good team works the same way. A good study hall does too. It is not a place where the work gets done for you. It is a place where you sit with other people, learn from what they bring, and then do your own work.

This is where AI fits, if it fits at all. The tool isn't the poet. It's the table. It holds the shared work in the middle, so the people around it can hear each other and then speak for themselves.

8. WHAT GOES WRONG

I want to be specific about the risks, because they are real.

The summary that becomes the truth. This is the most common failure, and it is quiet. An AI-generated summary enters the shared workspace. People repeat it. Within weeks no one remembers it was a summary, and no one is checking it. Everyone looks in step while fewer people are looking at the facts.

The wrong people seeing the wrong things. Student records, medical charts, client files and financial positions carry legal and moral duties. A shared workspace is only as good as its permissions. Some information should never be shared broadly, and some should never go into these tools at all.

Speed as an obligation. When a tool saves an hour, the easy thing is to fill the hour with more output. The better thing is to spend it on the part of the work only a person can do: the conversation, the mentoring, the second look.

The private room problem. Used alone, these tools don't connect anyone. A hundred people each talking privately to an assistant is a hundred more rooms, not one table. Connection has to be designed on purpose.

The skipped struggle. The blank page, the wrong first draft, the chord that won't come: these are part of learning, not obstacles to it. A tool that removes every struggle removes the learning with it.

9. RULES FOR A HEALTHY STUDY HALL

Here is the short set of rules I would want any school or company to adopt before putting a shared AI workspace at the center of its work.

Authorship is visible. It is always clear what a person wrote, what a tool drafted, and who approved it. **Dissent stays on the record.** Disagreement is kept in the workspace, not smoothed out of the summary. **Sources get checked.** Summaries point back to what they summarize, and someone looks. **A human signs off.** Every decision that matters has a name on it. **Privacy comes first.** Access is limited to the people who need it, and sensitive records stay out unless the rules allow them in. **Pace is respected.** The workspace keeps the shared thread; it doesn't set the speed of anyone's thinking. **Some work stays tool-free.** Every school and team should name the work that is done by hand, on purpose.

10. THE VERSE

In the film, Keating gives his students a line from Walt Whitman: the powerful play goes on, and you may contribute a verse. It is worth asking where AI sits in that line.

One answer is that AI contributes a verse of its own. Another, more uncomfortable answer is that AI is becoming the play, and the rest of us are being invited to add our verses to a script we didn't write. I think the best answer is neither. The tools can hold the stage: the set, the lights, the prompt book, the memory of what happened in the last act. The play, and every verse in it, has to stay ours.

This paper is a proposal, not a proof. If a school or company tries what it describes, it should measure it honestly: fewer dropped handoffs, less time spent re-explaining, less rework, faster help for the student or client who was falling through the cracks, and, just as important, whether disagreement and individual work survive. If those things hold, the tools are doing their job. If the work gets faster but the people get quieter, they are not.

As Anthropic and companies like it go public, the questions about them will get louder. Any of them could build the table. The ones worth trusting will be the ones that build it for people who still think for themselves, and that are willing to be held to that standard.

LET THE TOOLS HOLD THE STAGE. THE VERSE IS STILL YOURS.

APPENDIX: THE FIFTY PLACES

1. Kindergarten: the teacher and aide share the day's plan and the afternoon handoff. Human: how each child is supported.

2. Kindergarten: family notes drafted and translated for the teacher to review. Human: the relationship and the final word.

3. Middle school: shared calendars flag four big projects due the same Friday. Human: what to assign and when.

4. Middle school: teachers and counselors track agreed follow-ups so no student slips through. Human: understanding the student.

5. High school science: lab groups keep procedures and results across sessions. Human: the experiment and the conclusion.

6. High school counseling: shared deadlines become personal checklists. Human: the student's hopes.

7. Art class: a critique log follows each piece through its drafts. Human: the brush, the eye, the critique.

8. School orchestra or band: parts and rehearsal notes current for every section. Human: the music.

9. Debate team: research shared and both sides mapped. Human: the argument and the nerve.

10. Special education: everyone on a student's plan sees the same goals and progress. Human: the child and the family.

11. Grade-level teams: lesson ideas shared without everyone teaching the same lesson. Human: each teacher's style.

12. College research: who contributed what, and what is unresolved. Human: the question and the argument.

13. College team projects: decisions, drafts and roles in one place. Human: creative choices and disagreement.

14. Thesis committees: three advisers' feedback in one place. Human: the scholarship.

15. Law school moot court: authorities indexed, open questions flagged. Human: reasoning and advocacy.

16. Law school clinics: matters and deadlines tracked under supervision. Human: the advice.

17. Bar-prep study groups: who has covered what, and where the gaps are. Human: learning the law.

18. Medical school simulations: fictional cases handed between teams. Human: clinical reasoning.

19. Medical residency: sign-out notes that hold at three in the morning. Human: the patient at the bedside.

20. MBA case teams: conflicting assumptions surfaced early. Human: strategy and judgment.

21. MBA consulting projects: status and missing inputs tracked. Human: the recommendation and the client.

22. Restaurant shift change: inventory, reservations and broken equipment briefed to the next crew. Human: hospitality.

23. Restaurant purchasing: reorder lists drafted from sales and stock. Human: the menu and the quality.

24. Restaurant front and back of house: the allergy travels from the table to the line. Human: the care in the plate.

25. Hospital nursing handoffs, inside approved clinical systems. Human: assessing the patient.

26. Hospital discharge: unfinished steps flagged. Human: clearance and the conversation.

27. Hospital supplies: shortages flagged and work orders routed. Human: safety priorities.

28. Small law firm intake: conflict packets and missing-information lists prepared. Human: the conflict call and the advice.

29. Small law firm matters: task lists and handoff summaries. Human: strategy and client decisions.

30. Estate planning: client, lawyer, accountant and adviser see the same plan. Human: the family's wishes.

31. Family business succession: the founder's know-how written down. Human: trust between generations.

32. Affordable-housing deals: developer, lender, city and partners on one checklist. Human: the community.

33. Nonprofit grant reports: program, finance and development build the report together. Human: what the results mean.

34. Nonprofit volunteers: reminders sent and gaps flagged. Human: care and leadership.

35. Faith communities: meals, visits and volunteers coordinated. Human: presence.

36. Construction drawings: superseded plans flagged and questions routed. Human: design approval and safety.

37. Construction field reports: next-day handoffs from photos and punch lists. Human: workmanship.

38. Architecture studios: client changes reach every drawing set. Human: the design.

39. Wall Street morning prep: one briefing from research, trading and risk. Human: analysis and the trade.

40. Wall Street risk: possible breaches routed to the right reviewer. Human: escalation and the risk call.

41. Accounting close: who has reconciled what, visible to the team. Human: the judgment calls.

42. Newsrooms: sources, drafts and edits tracked across reporters and editors. Human: the story and its truth.

43. Customer support: the customer never has to tell the story twice. Human: empathy.

44. New-hire onboarding: the unwritten rules finally written down. Human: mentorship.

45. Software teams: code within reach of people who couldn't write it before. Human: what to build and why.

46. Coaching and therapy practices: scheduling and notes handled so the session is fully present. Human: the conversation.

47. Manufacturing shift change: open issues on the line passed to the next crew. Human: quality and safety.

48. City services: duplicate resident requests grouped and routed. Human: public priorities.

49. City meetings: promised follow-ups tracked. Human: deliberation and accountability.

50. City permits: stalled reviews across departments flagged. Human: code interpretation.

Sources: National Center for Education Statistics, Digest of Education Statistics 2007, Table 413 (internet access in public school instructional rooms, 1994 and 2003); Freshfields and Anthropic announcement, April 23, 2026; Middlebury Campus, "Blue books are here to stay," April 2026; Anthropic S-1 filing reported October 26, 2026. Film references are to Dead Poets Society (1989). Examples 1–30 were refined with help from a ChatGPT brainstorming session; the argument and the restaurant years are mine.